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Orality and the subaltern: Anticolonial resistance in Rosario Cruz-Lucero's *Feast and Famine: Stories of Negros*

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ABSTRACT
Rosario Cruz-Lucero's *Feast and Famine: Stories of Negros* decolonizes historical narratives by centring the lived experiences and oral traditions of marginalized communities in Negros Island, Philippines. The collection highlights how peasant workers and local storytellers resist the displacement, marginalization, and erasure of Indigenous systems of knowledge under colonial and neoliberal regimes. Through forms of orality such as *composos*, epics, gossip, and *oraciones*, Cruz-Lucero reconstructs historical imaginaries that challenge dominant narratives rooted in racial capitalism and elite historiography. These oral forms, often dismissed as non-serious or irrational, emerge in her stories as vital repositories of cultural memory, survival, and anticolonial resistance. Framed through the lens of pluriversality, the stories assert ways of knowing and being that resist the totalizing logic of capitalist modernity. Cruz-Lucero's work reveals how oral traditions serve not merely as cultural residue but as active instruments in confronting epistemic violence and reimagining decolonial futures from the margins.

KEYWORDS
Pluriversality; peasant consciousness; oral traditions; historical fictions; colonial modernity; anticolonial resistance

Feast and Famine: Stories of Negros by Rosario Cruz-Lucero (2003) is a collection of four short stories and one novella with an overarching narrative connecting the stories. It presents stories of the people of Negros through different forms of storytelling told by various characters. Published in 2003, it is predicated on an intergenerational approach, covering practically the whole of modern Philippine history.

A literary critic and author of short stories and books on Philippine literature, Cruz-Lucero has also written *Herstory* (1990), *La India, or Island of the Disappeared* (2012), and *A Reader in Philippine Film: History and Criticism* (2014). *Feast and Famine* presents a reinterpretation of history from the perspective of the working-class groups of people who live on the island of Negros, Philippines, groups that have been relegated to the margins by colonial and nationalist discourses in the archipelago that mainly prioritize Manila-centric and landowning class interests. This relegation to the margins, this article will argue, has led to the involvement of authors like Cruz-Lucero in the project of developing narratives that can account for the histories and identity/ies of the peasant working class and Indigenous groups of people. Moreover, these people's beliefs and practices are invalidated, as

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they fail to subscribe to a "universal" or mainly western assumption of rationality. This invalidation, I contend, serves to silence working-class and Indigenous voices and erase their histories, as their knowledge systems and cosmologies are deemed incompatible with the dominant national narrative. The forced assimilation into a homogenized national culture in the Philippines, along with the privileging of capitalist interests in a neo-liberal economy, further entrenches their marginalization.

The first section of this article situates Indigenous resistance in Negros within a broader historical context, demonstrating how colonialism and capitalist expansion have systematically marginalized Indigenous communities. Building on this foundation, the next section explores how *Feast and Famine* uses oral narrative forms – traditionally passed down through generations in Indigenous communities – as a means to resist and challenge the dominant historical narratives that have displaced Indigenous systems of thought. These oral traditions offer alternative ways of understanding history, emphasizing communal memory, storytelling, and lived experiences that counter the linear, progress-driven accounts typically associated with colonial modernity. The last section of this article argues that folk consciousness, deeply rooted in Indigenous spirituality and oral traditions, plays a crucial role in decolonizing historical narratives and asserting pluriversality as praxis. Pluriversality, a term popularized by the Latin American decolonial group Modernity/Coloniality – particularly in the works of Walter Mignolo (2011) and Arturo Escobar (2018) – refers to the coexistence of multiple epistemologies, cosmologies, and lifeworlds beyond the singular logic of western modernity. As Mignolo emphasizes in *The Darker Side of Western Modernity*, pluriversality is to a universal project in the plural, one that resists epistemic hegemony and affirms the legitimacy of alternative ways of knowing and being. Escobar, in *Designs for the Pluriverse*, similarly underscores how pluriversality emerges from the lived experiences and worldviews of Indigenous and other marginalized communities. Framing pluriversality as praxis not only challenges the epistemological dominance of colonial modernity but also reaffirms the importance of Indigenous knowledge systems in the ongoing resistance against cultural erasure and marginalization.

Previous studies of Cruz-Lucero's *Feast and Famine* have focused on the text's use of interlanguage, as evidenced in Cruz-Lucero's refusal to translate Hiligaynon[1] concepts (Villareal 2013); on how, as "vernacular literature", this text uses spirit-lore as part of its imaginative repertoire (Villareal 2010); and on how the narrative establishes intertextual links between history, theology, and postcolonial literary criticism in one of its stories (Wright 2007). However, such an approach does not touch on how the stories use forms of orality to present a pluriversality of consciousness as a way to decolonize history and narrative. Focusing on the narrative's intertextuality, this analysis precisely examines how the text challenges monolithic conceptions of history and postcolonial identity. In other words, I analyse how Cruz-Lucero's work suggests that Indigenous resistance, spirituality, and folk consciousness continue to offer alternative narratives that disrupt and challenge the dominance of capitalist and colonialist structures. In the next section, I will discuss the different layers of critique showing how Cruz-Lucero offers a systematic analysis of the colonial knowledge system. In doing so, she posits the pluriversal as a valuable alternative to universalist discourses anchored mainly to western assumptions of rationality and progress.

Enduring struggle and resistance: Peasant uprisings and the fight for land in Negros

Following Spain's distribution of Negros Island to 17 *encomenderos*[2] in 1571, the native population consistently resisted Spanish colonial rule to maintain their autonomy and way of life. From the late 16th to the early 19th century, Indigenous communities led sporadic uprisings against Spanish friars and missionaries, who aimed to eradicate what they perceived as pagan practices among the natives. The Spanish *encomienda* system, which imposed forced labour and tributes on the local population, was met with specific resistance from Indigenous communities. They continued to live according to their traditional sociopolitical structures centred around kinship and communal land ownership (Alcina and Lietz 1960; Lachica 1996).

Leading this opposition were the *babaylanes*, spiritual leaders regarded by the people as mediators between the spiritual and physical worlds (Cullamar 1986). Following the arrival of Spanish colonizers, the *babaylanes* and their followers faced persecution as part of efforts to eliminate pagan practices. Some of the most prominent of these *babaylanes* were Estrella Bangotbanwa, who was believed to have the power to summon rain after months of drought, Dupinagay and Tapara, Monica Gapon, and Augustina Hiticon, who all led armed struggles against foreign invaders seeking to impose their religion and ways of life on them (Regalado and Franco 1973). By refusing to submit to the monolithic imposition of colonial religion and culture, these leaders and their followers preserved their ways of life and knowledge systems, demonstrating that Indigenous epistemologies and cosmologies are as valuable as those of the colonizers.

Despite persecution, remnants of the babaylan tradition persisted even to the present day, continuing to influence peasant consciousness and resistance. In March 2024, for instance, babaylans from the Estrella Bangotbanwa Babaylan in Iloilo province in the Philippines performed a "Pana-et" by invoking the names of spirits and *datus* or tribal chieftains in early Philippine societies, chanting for rain to alleviate the heatwave and dry spell exacerbated by the El Niño climate phenomenon (Yap 2024). They performed this in the area where Fr Isidro Badrena, an Augustinian priest, died in April 1874 after trying to stop the babaylans from performing the ritual. The mystical powers of Estrella Bangotbanwa remain prominent in the local lore in the Panay and Negros regions. In Cruz-Lucero's *Feast and Famine*, the figure of the babaylan can be detected in the namesake characters of Estrella in "The Death of Fray Salvador Montano" and Estrella the *binukot* in "Doreen's Story", who is implied to be the same Estrella as in "The Death of Fray Salvador Montano", as well as Estrellita in "The Oracle of the One-Eyed Coconut" and Tiya Estrella in "The Composo of Hacienda Buyung" who can be deduced as descendants of the character Estrella in the first two stories. These characters, as portrayed in Cruz-Lucero's short stories, indefatigably resist and/or undermine colonial modernity's imposition of beliefs and political systems, specifically those of women's role in society and of the capitalist system. In doing so, they serve as the people's spiritual healers and leaders, even if they have been relegated to the margins of the community.

In Cruz-Lucero's work, I contend, this recovery of Indigenous beliefs in babaylans or shamans, *tamawos* or mythical creatures who have white skin, and *anting-anting* or amulets, constitutes a deliberate attempt to create pluriversal knowledge, a concept pervading the entire short story collection. By reviving and recentring the spiritual and

cosmological practices of figures like the babaylanes, Cruz-Lucero challenges the dominant epistemes conveyed by colonial modernity.

Following the opening of the Suez Canal and the development of steamships in the 19th century, there emerged a growing demand for sugar in the global market (Darwin 2020). As local economies became more integrated into global systems, focusing production on cash crops like sugar in order to meet international demand led to the expansion of plantations. This was particularly true in colonies like the Philippines, where cheap labour and land were exploited to maximize production and profits. As Alfred McCoy (1992) points out, large areas of land in Negros were devoted to sugar-cane cultivation. An economic boom led to the rise of a wealthy class of landowners who had control of most of the province's land, capital, and labour. These sugar planters came mainly from the Chinese mestizos of Iloilo, Molo, and Jaro districts of nearby Iloilo province. In contrast, their sugar plantation or hacienda workers came from the neighbouring islands of Panay, Bohol, and Cebu.

The hacienda workers consisted mainly of *indios naturales*, or the Spanish socio-legal category for the largest segment of native people who were not of ethnically mixed descent. According to Filomeno Aguilar (2019), these workers can be classified into two groups: the *agsas* (also known as *acsas*, *agsadores*, *aparceros*) or the sharecroppers, who were the permanent resident workforce in the haciendas, and the *jornaleros* or day labourers, who provided labour of a temporary kind, especially during harvest and crude sugar claying seasons (122). This labour division was widely enforced from the 1850s until the early 1900s, even with restrictions to mobility caused by the internal passport system that required *indios* to seek permission to travel from their *cabeza de barangay* (village head), *gobernadorcillo* (town magistrate), *alcalde mayor* (provincial governor), and *cura parroco* (local parish priest) (124).

In spite of such restrictions, the importation of labour from nearby provinces caused the population of Negros to increase by four and a half times in only half a century. Indeed, there were also *indocumentados* or undocumented labour consisting of *indios* who connived with planters to *sacar* or extract illegal labour from neighbouring islands. This process of extracting labour from neighbouring islands gave currency to the term *sacada*, which at present refers to transient migratory workers in Negros Island. From 9000 in 1867, the number of undocumented labourers increased to 35,500 in the 1890s, which made up a sizable portion of Negros population (Echauz 1894).

The end of the 19th century saw the rise of Indigenous resistance movements led by babaylanes. The best known of them was led by Papa Isio or Dionisio Magbuelas. Initially a babaylan, Papa Isio emerged as a revolutionary leader during the Negros Revolution. Declaring himself the "Pope of Negros", he led his followers, the *pulahanes*, in a series of attacks against Spanish forces and sugar-cane plantation owners. His rebellion was motivated by a desire to end Spanish exploitation, particularly the oppressive labour conditions on the sugar plantations, and to restore Indigenous ways of life eroded by colonial rule (Lachica 1996).

Following the fall of Spanish colonialism and at the beginning of American colonial rule, Papa Isio carried on with his resistance against the new colonial power, refusing to recognize American sovereignty. However, his struggle only lasted until 1907, when he was captured by American forces and later imprisoned. In contrast to Papa Isio, the character of Estrella in Cruz-Lucero's *Feast and Famine* remains in the tapestry of Negros

society, albeit sometimes on the sidelines. She continues to perform her role as the people's spiritual healer, *albularya*, *sacamuela*, and *binukot*.

With most land already encroached upon by the expanding sugar industry in the 20th century, the workers could no longer flee to the hinterlands as they used to in earlier times. This possibility was also restricted by the virtual disappearance of the frontier and the significant increase of the population of Negros province from a little more than 100,000 before the opening of the Iloilo port in the 1850s to over 1.1 million in 1939. Therefore, many *agsas* or share tenants eventually became *dumaan* or wage-dependent labourers who resided on the hacienda's premises. Since these *dumaans* were already dependent on the hacienda system, they no longer looked for other means of living elsewhere. Indeed, few other options were available to them on the island. The succeeding generations of these wage workers also became accustomed to a life of dependence, subservience, and poverty, which led to their "deproletarianization" (Aguilar 2019). They identified with the hacienda where they were born. In this process, they learned to address the planters as *toto* (brother) or *inday* (sister), as if they were part of this "fictive familial community" (139).

During World War II, Negros served as a site of significant guerrilla resistance against the Japanese occupation. The Indigenous populations of the island, already skilled in the use of the island's rugged terrain for defence, joined the guerrilla movements, contributing to the broader national struggle for liberation from Japanese forces. These resistance efforts were marked by a strong sense of local identity and autonomy, with guerrilla units often operating independently and relying on local knowledge and resources. However, after more than three centuries of colonial rule, the hacienda system became deeply entrenched on Negros island, where large estates, controlled by a few powerful families, dominated the agricultural landscape. This created a stark divide between the landowners and the hacienda workers, who were often forced into debt and servitude. Despite the long-standing oppression, hacienda workers continuously struggled to assert their rights, facing fierce resistance from hacienda owners, who used intimidation, violence, and legal manoeuvres to maintain control.

This fierce opposition from hacienda owners sought not only to maintain economic control but also to preserve a social order that placed them at the top of a rigid hierarchy. In this respect, the *sacada* system served to perpetuate the exploitation of workers. Indeed, it devised modern forms of labour control, binding workers into cycles of debt and servitude that echoed the earlier struggles for land and autonomy. Despite various land reform efforts, this system of contractual labour effectively deprived workers of security and rights, ensuring that the power dynamics established during colonial times remained unchallenged. Wealth and land ownership remained in the hands of the elite. For the workers, reclaiming their lands was not only a fight for economic survival but also a struggle for justice and self-determination. Despite facing violent reprisals and legal challenges, the determination of peasant workers to fight for their rights persisted.

Depicting anticolonial defiance through forms of orality

My approach emphasizes how orality in *Feast and Famine* functions not only as resistance but also as an archive of pluriversal historical consciousness. The use of forms of orality in decolonizing historical narratives, I contend, allows for the

reclamation and validation of Indigenous and folk knowledge systems that have been marginalized or dismissed in colonial texts. Among those forms, one can list community-based oral traditions grounded in displacement, survival, and solidarity, such as *sugilanon* or folk tales and *composos* or ballads, ritual healing practices such as *oraciones* that combine addresses to Catholic saints and pre-Christian deities, as well as *anting-anting* or amulets. Finally, the way in which women storytellers serve as keepers of folk knowledge plays a major role. These women destabilize *haciendero* "official" history by retrieving subaltern lifeworlds – rituals, rumours, supernatural accounts, and famine survival knowledge. In this way, they highlight the perspectives and experiences of those Indigenous peoples and peasant workers that colonial modernity considers as peripheral to its rigid vision of the world.

Orality, as argued by Walter J. Ong (1988), facilitates communal memory, immediate engagement, and a participatory mode of meaning-making. He writes that "persons in a primary oral culture can entertain some sense of proprietary rights to a poem, but such a sense is rare and ordinarily enfeebled by the common share of lore, formulas, and themes on which everyone draws" (131), emphasizing the social and embodied dimensions of oral culture. Postcolonial and decolonial scholars such as Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o (1986) and Mignolo, on the other hand, point out how orality serves as a counter-hegemonic tool against colonial domination. Wa Thiong'o insists on the decolonization of the mind through the recovery of Indigenous languages and oral traditions, arguing that "orature has its roots in the lives of the peasantry. It is primarily their compositions, their songs, their art, which forms the basis of the national and resistance culture during the colonial and neo-colonial times" (1986, 95). Mignolo similarly asserts that "racialization is applied not only to people, but to language" (2007, 17), pushing for epistemic disobedience as a way of rejecting Eurocentric knowledge systems.

Unlike Ong, who highlights orality's cognitive structures, or Wa Thiong'o and Mignolo, who foreground its political and epistemic ruptures, I focus on how oral narratives in Cruz-Lucero's text reconfigure history itself – foregrounding affect, memory, and Indigenous relationality as valid modes of world-making. Here, orality is not merely a vehicle of transmission or resistance but a generative, meaning-making practice that recasts marginalized lifeworlds as sites of historical narration and theorization.

Throughout *Feast and Famine*, Cruz-Lucero blends oral traditions with literary techniques, creating hybrid forms that bridge orality and literacy. As pointed out by Jack Goody (1993), orality and literacy coexist and shape each other within specific societies. The short story collection's narrative structures, which incorporate *composos* or ballads, gossips, police reports, and *oraciones* or prayer chants, demonstrate Cruz-Lucero's use of syncretic forms to reclaim a historical path deviating from or subverting dominant interpretations of history. For instance, in "Doreen's Story", the narrative interweaves police reports, a form associated with state authority and legal rationality, with prophetic pronouncements from a One-Eyed Coconut that provide oracles through oraciones, syncretic spiritual practice blending Catholic prayer and folk mysticism. Such forms reveal how Cruz-Lucero merges colonial bureaucratic language with oral and spiritual traditions to expose tensions between official state discourse and popular knowledge. These narrative modes are maintained through the "colonial matrices of power"

(Quijano and Ennis 2000) that foreground the Eurocentric perspective of history, but Cruz-Lucero subverts them by foregrounding hybrid, localized epistemologies. The use of oral traditions as narrative forms illustrates how the *indios*, and later the peasant working class, consistently engaged in varying degrees of subversion and defiance against the imposed consciousness of colonial modernity. In *Feast and Famine*, orality enables Cruz-Lucero to construct a pluriversal knowledge system where claims to truth are expressed in a more nuanced fashion. Indeed, orality presupposes community, which in turn immediately suggests a diversity of voices and perspectives.

In the short story "The Death of Fray Salvador Montano", for instance, Cruz-Lucero shows how during the Spanish colonial period, local epics were shared by the people, even though they already started losing significance due to the imposition of a colonial culture and religion. The *indios* were perplexed by the depiction of heroes as "scoundrels" and women as "shape-shifters" in the *Humadapnon* epic on Buyung Labaw Dunggun and Nagmalitung Yawa (Cruz-Lucero 2003, 31). *Humadapnon* is one of the three epics of the Hinilawod from the Panay Bukidnon people of the Visayas in the Philippines. Passed down through generations by *binukot* or secluded, highly trained female oral chanters, the Hinilawod epics recount the adventures of three demi-god brothers, Labaw Donggon, Humadapnon, and Dumalapdap. In the Humadapnon cycle of the epic, Humadapnon embarks on a long and arduous journey to seek a bride, encountering enchantresses, sorcerers, and shape-shifting women along the way. Among the most striking figures is Nagmalitung Yawa, a beautiful and cunning warrior-woman who uses her magical abilities – including shape-shifting – to rescue Humadapnon and defeat his captors.

This deviation from typical colonial or western portrayals of heroism and femininity, as noted by Cruz-Lucero, perplexed the converted *indios*, because in their eyes, these figures did not conform to ideals of Christian virtue or linear moral development. The epics apparently no longer reminded them of anything, as they "could no longer hear their 'mother's voices' trapped in their bone marrow" (8). For them, "Bard and Bore had become the same" (Cruz-Lucero 2003, 8). The appearance of foreign religion and diseases on the island further marginalized the local culture and practices. Unable to cure these foreign diseases, Estrella, the village *baylan*, agreed to be baptized so she could collaborate with the priest in healing her people. In return for urging the natives to abandon their "*bastos* songs", Estrella asked the priest to allow the natives to "sing their epics again" (11). However, these epics had become so unfamiliar to the people that even Estrella could no longer retrieve their endings. While they had evolved into *composos*, these epics resulted in songs whose fluid endings kept changing over time. As these narratives were already measured by Christian moral standards, Estrella could no longer continue singing them. Indeed, they could be bearers of the natives' history and culture as a people in the sense of capturing their changing beliefs and lifeways after colonial invasion and the advent of Christianity.

However, through the *composos*, the peasant workers asserted their traditions and subverted colonial thought. These narratives, communally produced and shared, intermingled colonial and Indigenous world views. In the same story, the *indios* alternate between the heroes of their local epics, specifically Labaw Dunggon, and the figure of the friar Fray Duertas:

> Fray Montano was not surprised when, soon enough, *composos* began to reach his pueblo about the wondrous ways in which Fray Duertas, from his new parish of Pueblo Minuluan, was making people fly through limestone crags, over bodies of water, and under the green canopy of jungles-all without the aid of the *monsala* scarf, betel nut chew, or the *busaw*'s golden strand of hair that were the vehicles by which the *indios* grandparents had once transported themselves from one place to another in an instant. (Cruz-Lucero 2003, 12–13)

The *indios* singing of the *composos* challenge colonial power dynamics, as can be inferred from the description of Fray Montano as the "fat and lazy *fraile* of Pueblo Buyonan, who spent his days sleeping in his convent, sleeping through the Mass, sleeping in the confessional" (14). These *composos* held much power in the people's life and imaginings because they

> were being sung around the island, from the coastal village of Hunob-Hunob in the north to the mountain fastness of Kanlaon in the south. When a traveling *manugcomposo* took it to a *tabuan*, where the people converged to barter their goods, another one would pick it up and take it to the next *tabuan*, where Duertas' feat took on even more miraculous proportions. (14)

However, as Cruz-Lucero knows, these power relations were inherently unequal, as the Spanish exploited the *indios* to serve their colonial ends. They were forced to repress or forget their ways of knowing and living in order to simply survive, and this led to a displaced and alienated consciousness. While remnants of their communal activities and practices persisted in their subconscious through their language and stories, they could no longer make sense of them as they used to, because of the negative influence of a foreign language, religion, and culture.

In "Doreen's Story", on the other hand, gossips play a crucial role in creating and developing stories belonging to the community during the American colonial period in early-20th-century Philippines. They perform a similar role in the temporal context of the story where the characters Doreen, Jonathan,[3] and one who can be presumed to symbolize Rosario Cruz-Lucero herself are sharing stories about a hacienda heiress named Anabella. This story recounts how the townspeople of Negros constructed narratives. When something happened in their town, they took time "to recover before they [started] ripping the narrative seams apart so they could peer into whys and wherefores" (Cruz-Lucero 2003, 44). Thus, the people created their legends and histories, which would define and shape their consciousness as a community.

This story illustrates how the American colonial rule transformed not only the physical landscapes but also the existing social hierarchy in Negros. The introduction of public education led to the rise of the middle class from the ranks of the working class, as exemplified by Francisco. He is first described as one of the "penniless children of plantation workers" (35), but later becomes the town dentist. Both public education and public health systems thus lead to the reshaping of the socio-economic landscape, cultural norms, and aspirations of the native people in Negros. However, as the new colonial state relied on the local elites to pacify their new colonial subjects, the American colonial period mainly solidified the power and dominance of the sugar planter class by backing their appeals for the reorganization of the sharecropping system. This prevented plantation workers from having an equal share in the hacienda profits. Instead, they became wage workers reliant on the plantation owners for their survival. This is

illustrated by Don Isidro, Anabella's father, who uses his *ikog sang pagi*, or sting ray's tail to punish errant workers on his hacienda. However, his workers still consider him as "a fair and generous *amo*" or boss:

> When a worker was whipped fifty times, we said he was being given "two cavans", because one cavan[4] you know, was equal to 25 *gantas*. But still, Don Isidro was a fair and generous *amo*. Everyday he watched to see who would do *karga-tapas* the fastest, and if the worker kept it up for a whole month, he was given two cavans at the end of the month. Real ones." And the old man pointed to himself and laughed gleefully. Then he shrugged. "Every man has his tool of the trade. I had my espading. He had his *ikog sang pagi*." (Cruz-Lucero 2003, 32)

The embedded story in "Doreen's Story" underscores Cruz-Lucero's illustration of how stories are shaped by the realities of their storytellers, specifically Doreen who tells the story of Anabella to her friends Jonathan and the narrator, the townspeople who have their stories to tell about Anabella and her family, and the storyteller, who is implied to be Cruz-Lucero herself. The characters freely change the narrative's direction, adding, omitting, or changing the details of the story after various forms of interruption. The latter may comprise a question from a friend, a research finding about a specific topic, or the death of the storyteller, Doreen Fernandez, a famous literary critic Cruz-Lucero had befriended. Thus, Cruz-Lucero subverts conventional narrative norms and structures by reversing assumptions about the ending to Anabella's story. To this end, she indicates that Anabella persisted in writing fiction and poetry, in spite of all the stories narrated about her. In doing so, Anabella rejected the demands of her parents and society that she remain an heiress.

> Or, when Anabella dies on September 14 next year, she will be discovered to have written 72 novels, 122 short stories, 7 novelettes, 5 *corridos*, 8 narrative poems of l100 to 1,000 stanzas each, 231 short lyrics, 7 long plays, 24 short plays and *dialogos* in verse, 7 volumes of essays, and 2 autobiographies.
>
> My generation needs its own legends too. (Cruz-Lucero 2003, 48–49)

Anabella, like the mermaid Bukay Ati or Estrella the *arbularya* in the story (or perhaps even more so), embodies the narrative of the *binukot*. The presence of these cloistered females in Indigenous societies dominates local epics (Abrera 2009). The *binukot* are known as chanters of tales and bearers of ancient and traditional wisdom. Indeed, their isolation from the community has made them more spiritually aware, enabling them to serve as mediators between the physical and spiritual worlds.

Therefore, the use of gossip as a fictional form can be decoded as Cruz-Lucero's means of highlighting the interplay between oral and written narratives. Estrella the *arbularya*, the known *binukot* in the text, shares stories with Anabella through chanting, showing the interaction between orality and literacy. She also insists on the link between Anabella and Doreen through the structural device of gossips, thus moving from literacy to orality. Likewise, she foregrounds the relationship between Doreen and Rosario Cruz-Lucero, when choosing to switch from gossips to short story as a narrative form.

Similarly, the portrayal of Anabella throughout "Doreen's Story" displays Cruz-Lucero's desire to reimagine history. In order to achieve this, she focuses on the perspective of female characters and writers who shaped the local literature and history of Negros. An instance of this method is the intertwining of the lives of Adela Ledesma, who is Cruz-Lucero's basis for the character of Anabella, the heiress

whose ill-fated love story became a town legend, and Magdalena Jalandoni, who became one of the most prolific writers in the Hiligaynon language (Nite 2019). In this way, Cruz-Lucero not only reclaims the female narrative but also challenges colonial and patriarchal impositions on how history and cultural memory are transmitted.

Just as the *binukot* in precolonial society facilitated the preservation of epics and oral traditions, Cruz-Lucero restores their importance in her literary world. This recuperation of the female as a custodian of oral traditions is also deeply rooted in the broader historical resistance to colonialism. While Indigenous communities opposed the displacement of their lands and cultures, Cruz-Lucero's use of orality functions as a form of intellectual and cultural resistance. Her characters, particularly Anabella, Estrella, Doreen Fernandez, and herself embody the continuity of Indigenous knowledge systems, as they reject the erasure brought about by colonial modernity.

By contrast, in "The Oracle of the One-Eyed Coconut", Cruz-Lucero foregrounds the perspective of those who lived during the time of Martial Law in 1970s Philippines through the structure of a police report. A certain Captain Baby Baltazar documents the viewpoints of each character implicated in the mayor's murder. This narrative structure illuminates the intersecting experiences of the individuals caught in the sociopolitical turmoil of the time, while also foregrounding the resilience of Indigenous cosmologies and practices through repeated allusions to Estrellita's One-Eyed Coconut.

Moreover, the period of martial law was marked by the presence of the New People's Army (NPA), the Civilian Defence System (CDS), and the Civilian Home Defence Forces (CHDF). Gun-for-hires also contributed to an atmosphere of random and systemic violence, making survival uncertain for many people in Negros. This especially affected the poor and even the "less wealthy", as violence served to protect the interests of the landed elite. Extreme poverty caused thousands of children and infants to die of malnutrition, exacerbating the people's sufferings. Religion began to influence political debates, as religious leaders intervened in public affairs, delivering politically charged sermons that impacted people's attitudes. The military's role in society also grew, as the number of paramilitary groups who served the landed elites increased. The disappearance of youths and individuals suspected of being communist sympathizers highlights the fear and uncertainty that pervaded everyday life in Negros, Philippines, in the 1970s to 1980s.

Folk spiritualities, however, remained strong, as exemplified by Estrellita's reliance on her One-Eyed Coconut to reveal oracles and to signal impending doom and catastrophe. The One-Eyed Coconut helped her find the corpses of the nine boys accused of being communist insurgents in the sugar-cane field. It also showed her visions of what happened to them as the *desaparecidos* or the disappeared. Oracles, by contrast, are dismissed as mere beliefs in favour of the objectivity and rationality of police investigations. The use of police reports as narrative structure contrasts with the One-Eyed Coconut's oracles. This shows how these two forms of orality intersect, both shaping people's lives during a period of social and political upheaval. As Estrellita uses *oracions*, leaves and roots to heal people, she is thought to be a witch who eats her children. Even though she tells people she is not such a monster, she is still constantly referred to as a "witch", whose beliefs and practices deviate from rationality:

> "But you're a witch yourself, aren't you?" Peejay mumbled, his eyes already shut. When he had a stomach ache, all she had to do was mumble an *oracion* and blow into his big toe and the ache would go away. When he was hot with fever and he vomited all the medicine that his mommy would spoon into his mouth, she would wait until everyone was gone and she would take from her magic bag of leaves and roots just the right thing to douse the fire in his body. (Cruz-Lucero 2003, 53)

Nonetheless, those people from her community who cannot afford the medical services in the town centre, and whose lives are considered expendable, still regard her as a healer. As Estrellita's *oraciones* and the oracles from the One-Eyed Coconut are dismissed as mere witchcraft and sorcery, those who choose to think otherwise are treated as pawns who can be eliminated for their inability to contribute to an economy of endless capital accumulation.

In the novella "The Composo of Hacienda Buyong", the locals' perspectives on their history are revealed through their performance of *composos*, which blend myth and history, undercutting any notion of a single truth and objectivity. The text illustrates how the townspeople spend their time gossiping and sharing composos. It points to the ways in which these stories have evolved over the years, accruing new endings, versions, or meanings. Each *composo* is shown to be deeply rooted in the distinct experiences and cultural backgrounds of its storyteller, showing how stories transform and adapt as they are passed down from one storyteller to the next:

> From the bag of jewels clasped in Toto Kiko's hand sprang many legends that slowly grew branches all around it, many of them sinking to the ground, weighed down by the many rings of truths they carried, each one taking root in the fertile soil of the people's imaginings. When Tiya Estrella began to sing the opening lines of the *composo* of Toto Kiko, people would gather 'round her store, ready to listen to a story they had already heard hundreds of times but ready, too, to be surprised at a new twist to it or a continuation to a story that they thought had already been brought to closure. "*O mga señores kag señoras, Pamati-i ninyo, akon iga-asoy ining higugma ni 'To Kiko*" [O, ladies and gentlemen! Listen, as I sing to you the love story of brother Kiko]. (Cruz-Lucero 2003, 85)

This aggregative and dialogic form of composos demonstrates how oral traditions evolve into more inclusive and multidimensional forms, challenging the monolithic narratives imposed by colonial modernity. The peasant workers gather to sing and share composos and to talk about the changes happening in their community. The latter involve the construction of a shopping mall over the top of a mass grave for cows. Indeed, the workers were told shopping malls would help attract foreign tourists and would prompt them to invest in Negros. The changes also include the tale of Toto Kiko's bag of jewels, and the tragic fate of Estrella, the people's babaylan, who was massacred by the Spanish soldiers accompanying Fray Duertas, as well as disappearances and rescues of individuals who were accused of being communist insurgents during the period of Martial Law in the Philippines.

Unlike written historical accounts that aspire to fixity and authorial control, composos accumulate new versions, endings, and perspectives, as they are communally devised, reshaped, and transmitted through oral performance by the people singing them. As the veracity of the details may shift with each retelling, their authority lies not in factual accuracy but in their capacity to affirm communal memory and respond to collective emotional and social realities. By emphasizing

this fluidity, Cruz-Lucero resists the colonial-modern imposition of a singular, linear history, and instead foregrounds a pluriversal mode of storytelling that centres the sensibilities of communities historically relegated to the margins. For these communities, beliefs embedded in composos are not quaint cultural artefacts but lived, tangible realities.

As each storyteller provides a different interpretation or ending of the story, Cruz-Lucero highlights the sensibilities of disenfranchised people. For them, their beliefs are real and tangible. However, colonial modernity, in its attempt to control the subjectivities of the "uncivilized", has distorted the meaning of these beliefs, turning them into mere curiosities (Chattopadhyay 2024). Cruz-Lucero's work subverts this tendency by positioning oral traditions as legitimate sites of historical knowledge and cultural resistance. Earlier critical receptions of *Feast and Famine* acknowledge this intervention, specifically Lawrence Ypil's (2003) "Unframing the House of History", which foregrounds the metafictional dimensions of "Doreen's Story" and reads it as symptomatic of local historiography, narrative mediation, and the instability of historical truth. Similarly, the review of *Feast and Famine* by Ma. Teresa Pineda (2004) highlights the collection's use of oral traditions and genre hybridity. Both works note how the collection destabilizes hegemonic national narratives and affirms the epistemic integrity of Indigenous and working-class world views.

In other words, the collection's composos kept accumulating and evolving, as the people constantly modified them. They freely added to them, showing the aggregative aspect of oral traditions. Although nobody really knows who caused what and why, the peasant workers gather to discuss and entertain themselves with the composos and all their mutable narratives. There is not one single truth to tell, but a plurality of versions revealing the sensibilities of peoples who were displaced to the fringes of society. In the same way as the composos allow the characters to reclaim their voices, the stories they tell collectively challenge the dominant narratives that have sought to silence and dismiss their experiences. The gathering of peasant workers seeking to entertain themselves with the composos inherited from oral tradition underscores the community's agency in creating their own historical narratives, even if they remain fragmented and ever-changing. This, I contend, underscores the pluriversal idea that there are multiple, coexisting ways of knowing and understanding the world. By emphasizing the communal nature of orality, Cruz-Lucero insists that knowledge is decentralized and shared by the people, rather than imposed from above.

This alternative system is rooted in shared values, Indigenous cosmologies, and a deep connection to the land, all of which stand in opposition to the exploitative structures of the hacienda system and neo-liberal capitalism. Thus, in Cruz-Lucero's work, orality serves not only as a form of storytelling but also as a critical tool for decolonizing knowledge. This recuperation of native resistance ties into the historical context of colonialism, in which oral traditions played a crucial role in maintaining Indigenous sociopolitical structures and cultural memory. While Indigenous and peasant uprisings constituted forms of direct resistance to colonial powers, the preservation and transmission of oral traditions also served as a form of intellectual opposition. They asserted the value of pluriversality and the role of oral knowledge in disrupting and challenging colonial narratives.

Conclusion: Storytelling as resistance and renewal: Pluriversal futures in *Feast and Famine*

In Rosario Cruz-Lucero's *Feast and Famine*, the Indigenous anticolonial lifeworld is revitalized through an emphasis on oral traditions connecting the seemingly diverse and disparate stories set on the island of Negros. Through the lens of pluriversality, it highlights the coexistence of multiple systems of knowledge and ways of being and counters the homogenizing forces of colonial modernity and global capitalism. Cruz-Lucero depicts how Indigenous and peasant communities continue to organize themselves in ways that reject the individualism and commodification central to capitalist economies.

By revisiting and reimagining anticolonial resistance, Cruz-Lucero indicates how the legacies of colonialism persist in contemporary times, albeit in more covert and systemic forms. Her recovery of anticolonial struggle serves as a reminder that the fight against oppression is ongoing. Indeed, the regaining of the anticolonial spirit of opposition goes beyond the fact of merely reclaiming past struggles: it also asserts the validity of these alternative epistemologies and lifeways in the present. In this way, in a world marked by ecological collapse and deepening inequality, *Feast and Famine* offers not only a counterhistory of Negros, Philippines but also a foregrounding of community-based epistemologies rooted in land, story, and kinship, aligning itself with movements in global decolonial thought that regard storytelling not only as resistance, but also as renewal.

Notes

1. One of the major Philippine languages spoken predominantly in Panay Island, Negros Occidental, and Soccsksargen with more than 9.1 million speakers.
2. *Encomenderos* were Spanish colonial agents granted control over specific territories and the Indigenous populations within them under the *encomienda* system, which functioned as a tool of both economic extraction and sociopolitical domination during the early Spanish colonial period in the Philippines.
3. These protagonists can be decoded as Doreen Fernandez and Jonathan Chua, respectively, who are respected literary critics and known to be friends of Cruz-Lucero.
4. A unit of mass or dry measure for rice equivalent to 60 kg or 75 litres.

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